Nehru understood that until India built its economic and military potential, the only way it could punch above its weight was as a champion of smaller nations in promoting a just and moral order in the world.

Championing the eradication of imperialism and colonialism were part of this strategy to rally the world's weak and downtrodden nations and emerge as their leader. It followed closely from India's own anti-colonialist struggle and was helpful in building close ties with other former colonies. The moral imperative and strategic dimension went hand in hand. The British legacy of viewing India as the dominant power in South Asia, with its power extending to the Middle East and South-East Asia, was echoed in Nehru's early speeches when he referred to India and China as the rising powers of Asia. Indian leaders saw their country as the natural leader for Asia and Africa, especially for fellow newly decolonized nations. According to veteran Congressman Jivatram Bhagwandas Kripalani, India's 'prestige' ran high even though it had just emerged as an independent state because it 'stood for the freedom of all nations and peoples and against all colonial or racial domination of one people over another'. [17]

As subjects in a former colony, India's leaders saw anti-colonialism as the defining issue in the post – World War II world. They refused to be drawn into the cold war or to let fear of communism frame their world view. Nehru declared in his first broadcast to the nation that India was 'particularly interested' in the emancipation of all dependent countries [or peoples] and in decolonization'.[18] India's founding generation viewed the legacy of colonialism as a threat to India's security and territorial integrity. Nehru saw non-alignment as an element of a scheme to 'pre-emptively contain the spread of the Cold War' as, in his view, conflict would have hurt recently decolonized countries like India.[19]

Nehru's goal of seeking the end of imperialism and colonialism tied in to his policy of building closer ties between India and the rest of Asia. The desire to rekindle India's ancient economic, political and cultural influence